



THE SECOND INTERNET

Recent snooping controversies have led to nations taking the path less travelled leading to the birth of the Second Internet.

Mithun Mohandas

A little news item passed by unnoticed back in 2012 when a new undersea cable was announced which would link all the BRICS nations together. It was nothing out of the ordinary as undersea cables are laid on a regular basis. After all, more bandwidth and lower latency is always welcome. Back then, it was incepted so that all communication between the BRICS would go through servers hosted in Europe and the United States (basically, the entire Northern Hemisphere). Reducing the time taken to get data across was the primary reason for investing in such architecture. After all, just two years back a cable was laid so that the folks working at the stock exchange could shave off a few milliseconds and not miss out on “opportunities”. The recent NSA snooping revelations have birthed another reason altogether for the cable – The Second Internet.

A little backstory

BRICS is a group of nations consisting of Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa. A group of nations that constitute 45% of the human population and 25% of the world's GDP. All of the member nations feature in the top 10 list of global internet users, and together they account for over 775 million internet users. So it's not a small group by any means. Earlier this year, a seemingly insignificant employee from the NSA (the one in the US)

decided to let the cat out of the bag. Turns out that the US was snooping on not only millions of US citizens but also citizens of other countries. Well this isn't surprising given that every spy movie out there has governments and security agencies portrayed in the same light. The difference here was that these “citizens” also included the first citizens of these nations.

Naturally, summits/meets were cancelled and ambassadors were given a strict dressing down. On the upside, it did get the policy makers thinking, they needed a way to ensure that state secrets remained secrets. In the meanwhile, we had the BRICS cable laying nearing completion and it didn't take much to put the

“Insidious government surveillance may be worse than outright censorship”

– Sir Tim Berners-Lee
(Inventor of World Wide Web)

two together. A few weeks later, Brazilian President Dilma Rousseff announced the creation of the second internet – one free from any interference by the US or the UK. Soon after the blowout, many countries publicly advised companies to start moving away from services provided by US-based companies in the view of providing greater security. Now, you'd think the onus is on the companies to decide whether they wish to continue their current arrangement with US-based companies but that's not going to be the case. Brazil is to vote on a law that will require all companies to store data regarding Brazilian citizens on Brazilian soil and nowhere else. That's just one nation at the moment or 100 million users, which is by no means a small number. Those 100 million users translate to a lot of revenue, and companies will have to cater to their demands or ship out and lose market share.

A new beginning

The internet is a network of many smaller networks. Then there are totally isolated networks as well – those that host military information and interconnect government offices are good examples of this. Even corporate offices spread out over a large campus have their own networks, so the concept isn't alien at all. The scale of implementation is the focal point here. Even on a global scale there exist layers